

CLEAN YOUR PHONE

A SHORT PRIMER
ON HOW YOU
CAN LIMIT THE DATA
YOU'RE GENERATING
FOR BIG TECH

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WHY IT MATTERS

Our digital life needs tending, cleaning, and mending just like other parts of our life. I'd argue our digital life actually needs more attention than a dirty sink right now.

Many of us think about our tech in binaries:

- Either you're someone who is a "techie" – a coder, a developer, a hacker – or you're a Luddite.
- Either you have everything in a complete perfect privacy bubble – or it's kind of a lost cause.

Both of these sentiments obscure the reality, which is that we all have the ability to better understand and manage our technology and data.

Even though we may not personally understand our technology – even though we don't see the mess the same way we see dirty dishes – it's there.

Let's get cleaning.

GROUND RULES

Do a little at a time and don't focus on being “done”

Do as much as you can. Do some cleaning and tending regularly. You're not going to do it all at once. It's not going to be perfect. It's also never going to be done, though it can be organized better from the start.

Stop it at the source

“All my data is already out there, why bother?” is a completely understandable feeling. What this misses, though, is that we are constantly generating new data.

Facebook and Google aren't getting rich off the photos you posted to MySpace fifteen million years ago – they are getting rich off the data you freely give them every hour of the day – all of which you can reduce, lessen, or even get rid of entirely.

GROUND RULES

Make it visible

Data and “the cloud” feel invisible to us. They don’t pile up on our counter. But they do create pollution and labor exploitation – even if we can’t see it. Find a way to make your digital life visible. Turn your digital cleaning into a routine chore.

Make it social and make it fun

The value that many tech provides is convenience: our phones make it easier and faster to do a ton of things. But that convenience comes with trade-offs. What interactions don’t happen when the answer is always in our pocket?

Talk about this with your friends. Host a party where everyone changes their phone settings.

You’re more likely to do it and more likely to stick with it if all your friends are doing it, too.

DELETE OLD APPS

**If you do not use an app regularly,
get rid of it**

Many apps (even the most innocuous ones!) are using the access granted by being on your device to track and share your data in ways that are completely unrelated to the purpose of the app.

An article from PC Mag¹ reported on apps that are the most invasive, with big social media apps topping the list. In reviewing the worst offenders, this is what one researcher² reported on Facebook / Instagram / Messenger/ Threads:

“These apps share a staggering 68.6% of your personal data with third parties, often for targeted advertising purposes...[n]early seven out of every ten pieces of information users provide, from contact details to location, is shared with external companies.”

Start with the worst offenders: Meta apps. Instagram, Facebook, Messenger, Threads, and WhatsApp: consider which of these you can do without and get rid of the apps.

Do an inventory and delete as many apps as you can. Feels better already, doesn't it?

TURN OFF AD TRACKING

Personalized advertising tries to offer us a service of “relevant ads tailored to your experience.” This is a fancy way of saying they are gathering precise data on your behavior and activity, without delivering anything that’s actually valuable to you.

APPLE

Settings > Privacy & Security > Apple Advertising and turn off Personalized Ads

ANDROID

Settings > Privacy > Ads > Delete advertising ID

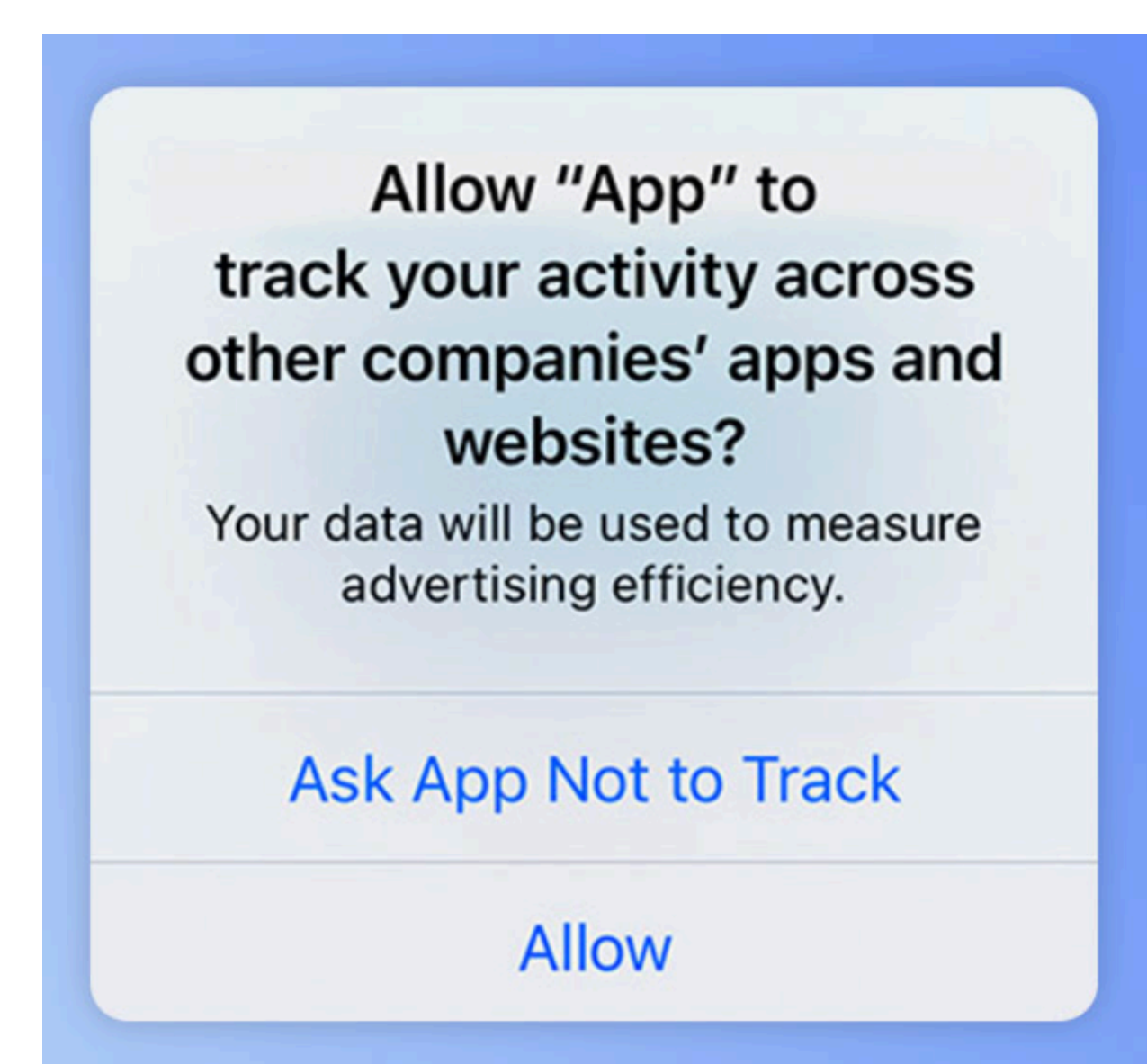
**WANT MORE INFO?
GO HERE:**



STOP CROSS-APP TRACKING

Apps don't need to track you even when you're on different apps. If you're on an iPhone turn off this setting completely, and it'll also mean you stop getting the popup "ask app not to track" box every time you install a new app.

Never get this popup again! Just turn it off.



APPLE

Settings > Privacy & Security > Tracking and disable "Allow Apps to Request to Track".

ANDROID

Unfortunately, this is not a feature you can turn off on Android for all apps. Some apps may have an option to disable or opt out of app tracking in their settings. You can look for this option and turn it off.

REMOVE MIC ACCESS

What apps actually need access to your microphone? Not many. Turn it off from the source:

APPLE

Settings > **Privacy & Security** > **Microphone/Camera** and revoke access for apps that don't need it.

ANDROID

Settings > **Security and privacy** > **Privacy** and turn off microphone access.

ANDROID BONUS * TURN OFF GOOGLE ASSISTANT'S MIC

This turns off the “background listening” that Google is doing for its assistant feature.

Open the **Google App** > click on your profile photo > **Settings** > **Google Assistant** > tap on “**Hey Google and Voice Match**” > turn off toggle switch next to **Hey Google**

BREAK THE GOOGLE DATA LOCK

Got a google account? Most of us do. Google can track detailed location and activity timelines – a great amount of data that they can sell and use. Turn it off in your account settings.

Go to: myaccount.google.com >>

Visit Google Account > **Data & Privacy** > **History Settings** and disable both Location History and Web & App Activity. This stops Google from building comprehensive behavioral profiles.



DISABLE ANALYTICS

Both Apple and Android report back on your usage to HQ aka Apple and Google. Turn this off from the source.

APPLE

Settings > **Privacy & Security** > **Analytics & Improvements** and turn off all options

ANDROID

Settings > **Google** > **Device Diagnostics** and disable data sharing

DISABLE LOCATION TRACKING

Check in on this. What apps actually need your location? Your maps app, sure. Other apps are not providing you an essential service by knowing your location – but they are getting valuable data from you by knowing your location. Turn it off.

Apple gives you the ability to review each and every app’s request. Android turns it off for the entire phone, which is less helpful if you ever do need to use location services. But in this case, you can turn it off and then switch it on if you need to use it.

APPLE

Settings > Privacy & Security > Location Services > Review each app or turn it off altogether.

ANDROID

Settings > Location > Toggle off “use location”

KEEP GOING

These are all tasks that can help you start the process of turning data off at the source. But there's a lot you can do to tackle that mound of dirty data dishes in your phone. Here are a few things you can consider doing:

- Host a party with friends where everyone cleans, deletes, and organizes our photos. Then share favorites at the end.
- Get an external hard drive and put files on it. Make a goal of getting off iCloud or Google (or both) and store your data physically.
- Get off Spotify and host a listening party with friends to talk about where we're all going from here.

Leo Burnett wrote and made this zine. Check out their website for links, references, and a lot of other half-done things: <https://leo-burnett.github.io/folio/>

Thanks to Jenny Ibsen for sharing her printer and her time to get these printed.

